

No Small CHANGE

The political career of Madhu Koda, the Independent MLA who was the chief minister for a record 23 months, is in jeopardy as the ED slaps money laundering charges

| By Amitabh Srivastava in Ranchi |

In the aftermath of the September coup d'état of 2006 that saw Independent legislator Madhu Koda usurping power in Jharkhand, the man known for his Machiavellian ambitions was often seen with his finger indexed in Mahatma Gandhi's *My Experiments with Truth*. Koda had then claimed he was reading the Mahatma's autobiography over and over again. At the beginning of his tenure, Koda who was just 36 at the time of taking over as Jharkhand chief minister, also promised "real change". But perhaps he only promised a change and delivered just symbolism; all experiments and little truth.

Though a new Government was in place with Koda at the top, the governance kept suffering from the law of diminishing returns in terms of delivering results and eliminating corruption. In the meanwhile, Koda remained surrounded by favourite freeloaders. No wonder, when the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on October 9 slapped charges on Koda and five of his former cabinet colleagues (besides two alleged associates), under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act for allegedly amassing assets running into several hundred

crores, it hardly raised an eyebrow in Jharkhand. Partly because it was not a number to gape at in the state's parlance, and partly because Jharkhand appears to have reached a stage where nothing shocks any more.

Earlier this month, the seizure of fixed deposit receipts of about Rs 14 crore from the Ranchi residence of Manoj Kumar Singh, private secretary of former Jharkhand minister Chandra Prakash Chaudhary, is a case in point. The ED's move has therefore largely been considered as just a question of records. Koda, who once entered into *Limca Book of World Records* for remaining chief minister for 23 months as the first Independent MLA, has now earned the dubious distinction of being the first (former) chief minister against whom an Enforcement Case Information Report, the equivalent of an FIR, has been registered. But the political ramifications of the ED's move are there for everyone to take note.

Times have changed for the worse for Koda, an Independent Member of Parliament in the 15th Lok Sabha. The charges slapped on him are foreign exchange violations and illegal overseas investments. Koda's alleged investments, estimated at Rs 300-400 crore, are just as widely spread from Singapore to Thailand, and from

